hold me (like a hostage)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/57934579.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Hostage Situations, Hostage Adora (She-ra), Captor Catra (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, theres no real timeline when this happens, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Catra Is a Tease (She-Ra), enjoy

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English

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by dead_frog

Summary

The sudden sound of a gun cocking snapped Adora out of her haze. She jolted for her gun she kept in her pocket but her hands were cuffed to a metal chair, along with the rest of her body. The cold barrel of the gun pressed to the back of Adora's head,

"Hey Adora,"

-

hostage adora / captor catra (its self explanatory)

Notes

ive been writing this for ages and i never actually posted this, hope you enjoy!

its all been written, i just don't know how many chapters im going to split this ,, short start! im aiming to update every 2 weeks :))) title is from billie eilish's 'hostage'

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

The sound of high heels loudly echoing against concrete woke Adora up. Her eyes squeezed shut despite the footsteps approaching- her head throbbed. She took a tiny peek at her surroundings and was met with confusion; she didn't recognise where she was. It looked like an abandoned warehouse; lit by beams of sunlight coming in from windows up high. It was empty apart from the couch in front of her. She barely remembered getting the villagers to safety, even after getting shot at multiple times (thank god for bullet proof vests), but the rest felt like a blur. The bruises felt heavy on her chest,

The sudden sound of a gun cocking snapped Adora out of her haze. She jolted for her gun she kept in her pocket but her hands were cuffed to a metal chair, along with the rest of her body. The cold barrel of the gun pressed to the back of Adora's head,

"Hey Adora,"

Adora's stomach flipped and she immediately stiffened against the chair, recognising that raspy, irritating, smug ~~and attractive~~ voice

"Untie me, Catra!" She shrieked, pulling against the cuffs. Adora’s blonde thin hair that was usually pulled back into a tight ponytail was now curling around her shoulder’s messily. Catra let out a high pitched giggle, cynical as always

"Does that work for the girls who tie you to your bed,"

"Fuck off," Adora seethed; leave it to Catra to make scandalous jokes about Adora.

"Oh baby," She smiled, shoving the gun to her head with more pressure, "you forget there's a gun to your head?" She stopped thrashing against the restraints, but tugged them as taut as they could go,

"How'd I even get here?" Adora gritted out. She couldn't remember much.

"Knocked you out on your way back," Catra said, twirling a lock of Adora's blonde hair, "so naive of you. Usually you’re better than this," Catra teased, her breath heavy in Adora’s ear,

"What do you want from me?” Adora hissed through gritted teeth,

"Just the Rebellion’s plans, then I'll let you free," Catra purred, finally walking around to the front of the chair. Adora looked Catra up and down, looking at the latex red turtleneck that left her arms exposed, her black painted nails and her ears twitching impatiently as her tail lashed curiously. Her once long mane had been cut short and slicked back- her hair curling around . The edge of Adora's lip twitched up,

"You wish," Adora smirked, smugger then someone tied up probably should be. She expected to catch Catra of guard, but Catra just leaned over Adora, right next to her ear,

"Don't say I didn't warn you, you have 24 hours to tell me, then you're dead" Catra whispered, Adora stiffening. Catra made a long and dramatic exit out of the warehouse, leaving Adora tied to the chair.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

enjoy!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

HOUR 1

"Don't worry, I'm still here," Catra snickered over an intercom. Adora rolled her eyes. Catra would probably torment Adora in her sleep,

"What’re you even doing?" Adora called out, unsure if Catra could hear her,

"Waiting on a friend, she's almost here," Adora hated how she could hear the mischievous smirk in Catra's voice,

"Good grief," Adora rolled her eyes as Catra reappeared out of nowhere to open the door, letting in her second in command, Scorpia, "Does Hordak know you're doing this?" Adora asked, trying to delay whatever Catra was preparing,

"Yep, except he thought I should've shot you," Catra said carelessly, like Adora's whole life wasn't in her cruel hands.

Scorpia and Catra walked around the warehouse for a few moments having hushed conversations. Adora couldn’t help but feel a small prick of jealousy, noticing the way Scorpia’s arm was slung over Catra’s shoulder and the way Catra held Scorpia’s waist,

“Kiss me,” Catra whispered as she smirked to Scorpia. Scorpia raised an eyebrow,

“Why?” Scorpia responded,

“To make her jealous,” Catra whispered, before giving Scorpia a long kiss. The edges of her lips pulled into a smile as she felt Adora’s deadpan expression glaring at her- she didn’t even need to look at her to feel it,

“What’s your plan,” Scorpia asked in a hushed voice, careful to not let Adora hear,

“You *know* my plan,” Catra raised her eyebrow, still holding Scorpia close

“What if it doesn’t work?”

“It’ll work,” Catra narrowed her eyes at Scorpia before she dropped the whisper and spoke in her normal voice, “maybe you should go now, that’s all I wanted to talk to you about,” Catra gave Scorpia a small smile- in between a smirk and something vaguely loving. Adora frowned- she used to be that person for Catra. Catra went on her tiptoes to kiss Scorpia again, wrapping her arms around the back of Scorpia’s head the way she did for Adora back when they were dating, “I love you, Scorp,”

"I love you too,” Scorpia whispered, giving Catra another kiss, “See you later, Wildcat," Scorpia said, walking out of the warehouse.

“You guys have nicknames for eachother?” Adora frowned, blowing a stray hair out of her face

Catra shrugged, “So what? You jealous?” Catra smirked,

“No…” Adora deflected badly. Catra rolled her eyes before messing around on her device and doing god-knows-what whilst Adora tensed nervously- she’d never been very good at silence,

Catra hit play on her phone and her music began playing through the whole warehouse. Adora looked confused, watching as Catra leaned back into the sofa and sighed. The rock rhythms pulsed through the floor and Adora's headache throbbed louder,

"What are you doing?" Adora asked,

"The only thing I want to hear from your mouth is the Rebellion's," Catra smirked. The music was the same stuff Catra would listen to when she'd share her earbuds with Adora; Back when Adora was with the Horde, because she was indoctrinated into thinking that they were the good guys. She escaped the Horde, but Catra refused to follow along.

"I have a headache Cat," Adora shouted over the music, but Catra just ignored her, listening to the melody, "please,"

"What do you expect me to do about it?" Catra joked,

"I don't know, turn down the music? Give me a pill?" Adora shrugged,

"You'd take a pill from your enemy? That's not very smart," Catra teased in a condescending tone. Adora rolled her eyes,

"There's not a lot of horrible shit you could do and you aren't my enemy," Adora corrected,

"You're joking," Catra frowned, "what, is there someone bigger and badder?" Catra's tone returned back to teasing but it was mostly curious,

"No, you just aren't big or bad," Adora shrugged,

"I'm not bad?" Catra laughed incredulously, but looked back to Adora's serious expression, "I'm not bad?" Catra repeated with narrowed eyes,

"I know deep down you wouldn't-" Catra pretended to punch Adora, stopping her fist millimetres from Adora's face to see how

she’d react. Adora didn't even flinch, blinking blankly at the fist near her face,

“You're an idiot,”

“For not flinching at a punch that didn't touch me?” Adora shrugged, “there's no harm, why would I?”

“Why do you trust me?” Catra scowled,

“It’s hard not to when I grew up with you. I know you Catra,”

“If you know me so well what's my kill count,” Catra said nonchalantly,

“No… you wouldn't,” Adora whispered. Her blood was cold, “you told me you wouldn't,”

“Try me,” Catra looked at her nails,

“Ten?” Adora said sheepishly. Catra scoffed,

“Zero. You really don't know me,”

Adora swallowed dryly, unable to fill the silence… until, “it’s going to be one after today. If you kill me,”

Adora wanted to get a rise out of Catra, but Catra walked away.

HOUR 2

Adora was alone, desperate and craving to talk to someone. Adora was never good at being alone. She was always locked in rooms and kept away from other cadets when she was bad at the Horde. This felt the same. Adora kept calling for Catra, but was met with silence. Her brain was getting louder.

HOUR 4

"Catra!" Adora shouted for the hundredth time, before hearing something shift behind her. Catra appeared in front of her with a cocky grin on her face,

"What?" Catra shrugged as she sunk into the couch across from Adora. Adora didn't have anything to say, she'd just prefer the company of Catra over being alone,

"You were gone for ages," Adora frowned,

"So what," Catra hummed, playing with her gun like a child with a toy, "you're the hostage, not me,"

"Oh piss off would you?" Adora hissed. Catra looked at her with a raised eyebrow and began to walk away, "Wait! Catra!" Catra looked over her shoulder with a shit-eating grin, "don't go,"

"Oh? What was that?" Catra smirked, turning around and looking at Adora,

"I said don't go," Adora grumbled,

"Aw, baby," Catra smiled, walking up to Adora and holding a hand to her face, "are you lonely?" Adora swallowed through her dry throat,

"If I say yes will you stay?" She grumbled,

"Sure,"

"Then yes, I am lonely," Adora rolled her eyes,

"Good girl," Catra said mischievously, sitting right on Adora's lap,

"Do you have to sit *right* there,"

“What?” Catra said innocently, batting her eyelashes, “I’m not doing anything,” Adora frowned, nose twitching as Catra swatted it with her tail. Adora felt fuzzy inside as Catra began to purr, a smirk pulled over her face.

It was then that Catra realised something crucial, “tell me the Rebellion’s plans and I’m yours,” Catra whispered, noticing the way Adora’s eyes flickered to Catra’s lips.

Adora still had a crush on Catra- the thing Catra could use to her advantage.

“No,” Adora murmured, looking up to Catra’s eyes. Her eyes were half lidded, and there was a small amount of blush over her face. Catra pressed a small kiss to Adora’s neck,

“You can have me in any way you want,” Catra drew a finger across Adora’s jaw, “all of me, if you just tell me,” Catra’s expression was soft as she carded through Adora’s hair, twirling a strand, “when was the last time you got something *you* wanted. Not for your stupid rebellion but for you,” Catra pressed her forehead to Adora’s, “you deserve to *want* as well,”

“No,” Adora mumbled again, before squeezing her eyes shut, “it doesn't matter what I want… You will never get their plans,” Adora spat, hating the disappointed sigh that escaped Catra’s lips,

“Oh well,” Catra muttered much to Adora’s chagrin, “I guess you don't want me,”

“You know that's not true,” Adora frowned, eyes still squeezed shut, “you know me better than anyone,”

“What about your sparkly friends?” Catra raised an eyebrow as she shifted off Adora. Adora’s eyes snapped open to the sound of heels clicking away.

“You *know* that's different,” Adora narrowed her eyes, watching Catra pause and turn around

“Please, enlighten me,” Catra hissed,

“I was in love with you,” Adora frowned, “didn't you love me?”

“I didn’t love you Adora,” Catra responded, delivering it like a stab to Adora’s chest, “get over yourself,” She said cruelly, collapsing onto the couch. Adora felt like she was bleeding all over herself, blood spilling from her chest. She could feel the searing hot feeling and the blinding pain rip into her chest. A stray tear fell from her eye and she refused to blink, staring with hurt as Catra pretended to be overly interested in her gun. Her eyes felt dry, her clothes felt too tight and her legs ached from being in the same position.

Catra’s music looped, pulling the heartbroken dagger in Adora’s chest in and out… in and out… in and out. It hurt to be so blindly vulnerable to someone who craved to hurt her.

HOUR 5

At some point Catra left. Time was getting less linear to Adora. Adora still felt the ghost of Catra’s warm lips on her neck. The warehouse was getting darker and darker as the sun set and with it Adora grew more scared that she’d never make it out.

HOUR 7

“Y’know what the fucked up thing is?” Catra let out a long, exasperated chuckle as she walked up to Adora from behind her. Adora’s head shot up. It was pitch black but usually Catra’s eyes would glow in the dark. But she couldn’t see anything infront of her, “the fucked up thing is that I’m loyal to the Horde and all they

want is you," Adora didn't know how to respond, especially as she watched Catra turn on a small desk light and slump onto the couch with a glass of whisky, "I mean seriously," Her tone was far darker now, almost as dark as the circles under her eyes, "*everyone* wants Adora,"

"Not you," Adora frowned. Catra gave her a bitter look,

"Yeah, yeah," She muttered,

"Why don't you just come with me?" Adora whispered, staring to the floor. This was an old conversation that had been spoken too many times,

"Get it through your massive hair poof. I'm not joining your rebellion," Catra scowled, sipping more of her drink, "I'm doing great at the Horde, I'm getting promotions,"

"But what happens when you get to the top?" Adora pointed out, leaning back comfortably in her chair, "there's only so far you can climb up the ladder before you're stuck at the top and *alone*,"

"Being alone is great if you ask me," Catra drunkenly laughed, throwing her head back, "no one left to hurt me," Catra stopped laughing to glare at Adora, the weight of the world in Catra's irises,

"I didn't mean to hurt you by leaving," Adora said sheepishly, "but the Horde was and is hurting so many innocent people-"

"So I wasn't innocent?" Catra cut her off. Adora's eyebrows furrowed,

"What? You blow up *whole* villages with your bots. You're taking control of Etheria,"

"What about before that? You *know* I was abused," Catra muttered, massaging her own hands, "you were *fine* with watching me get hurt but you see *random* strangers getting hurt and suddenly you can't put up with it,"

“Catra,” Adora said hoarsely, unsure of what else to say. She’d never looked at it in that light,

Catra’s tone got darker and louder, “You were **fine** watching Shadow Weaver put me through hell-”

“I shouldn't have been. I didn’t know any better Catra,” Adora admitted, “I’m sorry. I should've done something. You must've felt alone-”

“I didn’t feel alone, I *was*!” Catra yelled, “I was *so very* ***alone***, always coming second to you and being called the pest *stuck* to you, but I guess that was *a-okay* because everyone liked you!”

“I know,” Adora didn’t engage in yelling, trying to pacify Catra,

“Worst of all, I don’t know what I want from you!” Catra cried before she downed her drink in a pitiful attempt to drown her tears,

“I can’t change the past, but we can fix the present,” Adora started slowly, “we were taught all the wrong things. I’m still unlearning it all but you can too. You’ll be safe,”

“Not true,” Catra slurred, “*you're* safe because you're worth something to the rebellion so you’re worth keeping around. You have value to them as She-Ra. Most Horde defects get killed within their first year of so called *freedom*,”

“What? That’s not-”

“True?” Catra finished for Adora, “I deal with the statistics myself. It’s about a 80% chance. Bet they don’t tell you that in the rebellion,”

“I had no idea,” Adora stared at her feet, “I’ll keep you safe, I promise,”

“I’m never gonna trust a promise from you again. I learnt my lesson,” Catra mumbled. turning into the couch.

Silence ensued. Adora was nervous to break it,

“You cut your hair,” She peeped quietly,

“So what?” Catra uttered defensively, crossing her arms despite being faced away from Adora,

“It’s nice,”

“I never asked for your validation,” Catra scowled derisively,

“It’s not validation, it’s a compliment,” Adora rebutted as she slumped in her chair, “why’d you cut it?”

“I didn't want to,” Catra bit, clearly defensive, “Hordak was mad at me and yanked my hair. So I realised it was a weakness and-” Catra made a scissor motion with her hands, “-just got rid of it,”

“You loved your long hair,” Adora whispered ghostly,

“My hair made me vulnerable and easy to attack. It’s better shorter anyways,” Catra wearily responded, “Doesn’t weigh me down. Makes my attacks… lighter,” Catra’s drawling turned to slurring as she brought her knees to her chest and curled up, ready for a nap, “do you ever wish things could be as simple as they were when we were little?”

“All the time,” Adora admitted, “but I can’t just *pretend* things are different,”

“Alright then,” Catra muttered in a low tone, “goodnight,”

HOUR 8

Adora woke up feverishly gasping, not even realising she was asleep and dreaming until her eyes blinked open. She was shaking as she realised it was just a dream. Her breaths came out in

jagged gasps, “You okay?” Catra yawned, clearly having woken up from Adora’s burst of breaths,

“Mhm, just a nightmare,” Adora addressed as she tried to still her own hands. Nothing was working, so she swallowed her pride and managed to ask in a whisper; “can you come here? I just want to hold you again,”

“I don't have anything on me that you can escape with,” Catra mumbled but she was already standing for Adora,

“I know,” Adora responded, “I just miss holding you,”

“Okay,” Catra whispered, much to Adora’s surprise. She walked over and sat on Adora’s lap again. Catra perched into the nook of Adora’s neck. With what little movement Adora had against the restraints she used to hold Catra. Catra was still far too drunk and managed to doze off,

“I love you,” Adora said hoarsely.

Little did Adora know Catra wasn’t asleep yet.

HOUR 13

Both Adora and Catra woke up to the sound of Catra’s phone ringing over the speakers. It's blaring sound caused Catra to groan, “fuck,” She muttered, rolling off Adora. Adora similarly scrunched her eyes up and let out a loud groan, “sorry, I’ll get it,” The warehouse was still dark which meant it was still nighttime, so who was calling at this time?

“Hey Catra?”

“Hm?”

“I missed you,” Adora had a shy smile on her face,

“You too,” Catra muttered back, grabbing her phone, “Catra speaking,” Catra held the phone to her ear lazily, before her posture snapped up, “you said you’d give me 24 hours,” Catra scowled, “no I’ve almost-” Catra cut herself off as the person on the other side of the line hung up. She threw her phone angrily, watching it shatter across the floor of the warehouse

“What was that?” Adora asked curiously, watching Catra circle behind the couch to grab something. A *key*,

“You’ve gotta get out of here, Hordak’s coming,” Catra spat, “he’s gonna use you to get your friends and then he’ll kill all of you,” Catra fumbled to undo the cuffs, freeing Adora’s hands then legs, “go!” Catra yelled,

“What about you?” Adora asked apprehensively as she stood. Catra reassessed the way she was standing and paused, visibly shrinking into herself,

“There’s nothing left for me. Just leave,” Catra turned her back to Adora, walking away, “hey Adora? I’m sorry for what I’ve done. Or I guess I’m just sorry for everything. Might be the last time I get to say something to you,” Catra was staring at the floor, facing away from Adora because it would be too hard to see the look on her face, “I’m sorry that I was there in the Fright Zone when we were three. Maybe the world wouldn't be so messed up if I weren’t here,”

“Don’t apologise for that part,” Adora frowned before uttering; “*I’m* sorry for what I’m about to do,” Catra turned her head confusedly before being trapped in a headlock. She dug her claws into Adora’s arm and *pulled down* but all Adora did was yell out. Despite Catra’s kicking and flailing, Adora didn’t relent. Her headlock was too tight and Catra felt her vision begin to fade.

Chapter End Notes

ik there are prolly errors but this is just a fun little writing thing

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> its a bit divergent to how things happen in the show,,, this fic is pre-prime btw. I honestly have no idea if this chapter makes any sense??? LMAO

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

HOUR ???

Catra blinked her eyes open, confused at the heavy feeling around her wrists. She tried to shuffle from the spot she was sitting in but her ankles were tied tightly to the legs of the chair. Her hands were bound to the chair, “hey Catra,” Adora teased,

“Wow,” Catra rolled her eyes, leaning back into the chair like she didn’t feel a flurry of panic in my chest, “cute setup, Adora. *Really*,”

“Thanks I took some inspiration from my last captor,” Adora smirked,

“Hmmm, I heard she was really hot,” Catra drawled, eyes half lidded crescents,

“You're one of the few people that cockiness looks great on,” Adora muttered, leaning forward to be face to face with Catra,

“I also look great with nothing on,” Catra flirted. Much to Catra’s delight, Adora went bright red. Catra stuck her tongue out and licked Adora’s nose. Adora giggled, “Catra!”

“What’s your aim here?” Catra raised an eyebrow, pressing her forehead against Adora’s,

“I’m taking you to Brightmoon,” Adora smiled. Catra reeled her head back and slammed it into Adora’s, both of them groaning, “what the hell, Catra!” Adora frowned, rubbing her forehead,

“I’m not going to Brightmoon,” She scowled,

“You don’t have much of a choice,” Adora shrugged. Catra broke out of her restraints with her claws, to no surprise of Adora, and booked it towards the door. Adora grabbed her tail, yanking Catra back and shoving her into a corner of the room,

“That hurt!” Catra yelled, grabbing her tail to soothe the ruffled fur, “just let me go,”

“What, so you can go back to the Horde?” Adora rebutted, “they're gonna kill you, are you stupid?” Adora seethed. Catra looked to the ground,

“I know that, Adora,” Catra gritted back, jaw clenching in anger,

“Why would you go back to the Horde if you know they're gonna kill you,” Adora hisses

“Because I know you all hate me,” Catra shouted,

“I’ve never hated you!” Adora shrieked. Catra’s eyes went wide before her whole frame shrunk, “just come to Brightmoon. I’ll keep you safe,”

“I’m not going anywhere with you voluntarily. You'll have to knock me out again to drag me away,”

“I’m just gonna cuff you,” Adora said, cornering Catra. Catra took a deep breath, hands shaking as she cowered in the corner as much as she could after Adora locked the cuffs. Suddenly, Catra shrieked as she was electrocuted, her body convulsing. Her hands snapped to the back of her neck,

“What's happening!” Bow gasped as he barged in,

“I don't know!” Adora shrieked back, “Catra!”

Catra was gasping for air as her muscles finally relaxed. Her eyes were shrunk to pin pricks and she began to scrabble at the back of her neck the best she could with handcuffs on, drawing blood. “stop!” Adora shrieked, grabbing Catra’s hands,

“There's a chip in my neck! They're tracking me,” Catra hissed, fighting against Adora’s relentless grip,

“A chip? Since when did the Horde chip people,”

"I’m second in command, Adora," Catra looked away nervously, “of course Hordak put a leash on me,”

"Second in command?" Adora’s jaw dropped,

"Unlike you, I keep my goals. Now get me a towel so we can get the chip out," Catra responded. As Adora left the room with Bow, she dug her claw into her neck, trying to find the small piece of metal. When Adora returned to the sight of Catra having stabbed herself with her own nails, she grabbed Catra’s hand immediately,

"What are you doing?!" Adora shrieked,

"Getting the stupid tracker out!" Catra hissed back,

"I have tweezers. Let me do it," Adora insisted, looking at the back of Catra's neck. Catra stayed still but she looked restless,

"Once it's out you need to evacuate, the Horde gets an alert when someone rips out their chip," Catra grunted as Adora found the chip and pulled it out; snapping the tiny piece of metal into two. Adora brought the towel to the back of Catra’s neck and held it there as it soaked up the blood.

Adora helped Catra up and went to help her walk when Catra glared at her, “don’t even think about it,” She hissed

“Bow," Adora said hurriedly, "we need to go,"

Bow stood from his spot on the couch and rushed to the car. Catra and Adora sat in the back of the van whilst Bow drove, "let’s go to Brightmoon, we'll get Glimmer’s help," Bow instructed.

Adora now sat side by side with Catra, whose eyes were unfocused. The towel on her neck was already red, "Shit," Adora cursed, "you're bleeding a lot," Adora whispered, tilting Catra's face towards her, "can you focus your eyes on me?" Adora asked. Catra felt dizzy, swaying back and forth slightly as she kept her eyes trained on Adora, "is there a first aid kit in the glove box?" Adora asked, biting the inside of her lip anxiously,

"There's nothing in here," Bow responded. Adora groaned, taking off her jacket.

"Show me your neck," Adora instructed,

“No,” Catra protested weakly,

“Catra please. You're about to faint,” Adora rebutted sternly,

“I can take care of myself. I don't need you,” Catra mumbled. Adora's eyes widened and she calmed her tone,

“Okay,” Adora frowned, “I can let you do your own thing but you're losing a lot of blood. I just want to make it stop,” Adora’s eyebrows pinched together and her face firm in a frown,

“I hate you,” Catra grumbled, before relenting and turning around with her back facing Adora. She pulled the soaked towel off and Adora pressed the jacket on. Catra used the handcuffs to apply pressure- putting her hands behind her head and pushing them forward so that the chain pressed against her neck.

“Catra,” Adora whispered,

“What,” Catra hissed, but it was weak; the usual bitter tone in her voice quivering,

“Stay,” Adora responded. Bow glanced at the two girls from the rear view mirror, unspoken words he couldn't read behind their eyes,

“Fine,” Catra responded softly,

“Promise?” Adora whispered back, leaning closer to Catra.

“You first,” Catra narrowed her eyes. Adora thought that was low, but she understood,

“I promise,”

“I promise too,” Catra murmured. So little words were said between them, yet their hearts felt heavy.

“We're here,” coughed Bow, unsure of how to interrupt their conversation. They were underground, Catra hadn't even noticed the car driving or how long they'd been in the car for.

Adora guided Catra to an elevator and punched in a code, opening the door.

As the elevator lifted, Catra swayed back and forth. She was trying to keep pressure on her neck, but she felt dizzy,

“You need to focus,” Adora said in a measured voice, “talk to me about something,”

“Scorpia and I aren't dating. I just wanted to mess with you,” Catra groaned, head leaning back against the cuff chain,

“Seriously?” Adora whined, “I thought so but then you told her you loved her,”

“Well you love your best friends, don’t you,” Catra teased, but her face was so pale,

“True, but I don't kiss them,” Adora muttered and the elevator door opened.

“Adora!” Glimmer said with relief before gasping as she saw Catra, “what are *you* doing here!”

“She’s injured Glimmer! She needs to see the medics!” Adora sputtered, unprepared for the door to open so abruptly,

“Likely story,” Glimmer spat sarcastically, so Catra turned around, showing Glimmer the blood stained jacket on the back of her neck. Glimmer grimaced before grabbing Catra and teleporting her.

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It was hours before Adora was allowed to see Catra. When Adora barged into Catra’s room, she didn't expect to see a force field separating them. Though Adora can't say she was surprised; Glimmer had every right to not trust Catra, “Is your neck okay?” Adora asked sheepishly, trying to start conversation,

“It's fine,” Catra whispered back, “I don't want to be here, Adora,”

“You promised me you'd stay,” Adora fretted, biting the inside of her lip,

“I didn't say I’m leaving, I said I don't want to be here,”

“Ok,” Adora sighed; she could live with that, “I think I can get through the barrier,” Adora pressed her hand against it, but nothing happened. She frowned, leaning against the barrier “or not,” She mumbled, sitting with her back against the divider.

Catra did the same, her back against Adora’s- the divider separating them. Catra let out a sigh, before the door swung open and she got up and frowned, “Horde scum,” Glimmer growled,

“Sparkles,” Catra hissed, standing straight with her arms crossed,

“Get out Adora, Catra and I need to have a chat,” Glimmer gritted,

“No,” Adora responded. Glimmer’s eyes widened,

“I’m the queen! You can't deny me,”

“So arrest me,” Adora shrugged, “I’m staying here with Catra,”

“Adora, You're under arrest for insubordination,”

“Seriously?” Adora’s jaw dropped, “what is wrong with you,” She hissed, “don't forget what you promised me,” Adora said to Catra,

“Ditto,” Catra frowned as Adora was taken out of the room. Glimmer crossed her arms at Catra,

Glimmer waited for the door to shut before her lips pursed into a tin line,

“Here's how this is gonna go,” Glimmer stated, “you have a royal court appointment in three hours. You will be submitting yourself to a formal execution,” Catra snorted,

“Why would I do that,” Catra’s face pulled into a smirk, “you don't control me, Sparkles and I know your rules about execution. You can't force one on me,”

“Well Adora’s now being held in a cell under Brightmoon custody,” Glimmer commented, an unspoken threat lingering behind her words. Catra paused,

“You wouldn't hurt her,”

“You don't know me,” Glimmer rebutted, “and you don't know what I’ll do just to get you gone. I lost all empathy for you when you pulled that lever to the portal. The portal my *mother* died in. There is no one left for you Catra, not a soul on Etheria that wants you. I will do anything it takes to avenge my mother and I will never stop until I’ve exterminated you and every Horde soldier that aided in her murder,” Glimmer left the room in silence, leaving Catra to mull over her thoughts.

Eventually she collapsed onto her knees. There was only one option.

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Catra was dragged into the throne room by Brightmoon’s guards, where Glimmer sat perched on her throne with a neutral expression. Catra looked back to the audience, noticing how Adora was allowed to attend. A small gathering of people watched her, a certain disdain in their eyes. But not Adora's; all Adora's eyes held were a sorrow of worry. Catra was shoved to her knees, and got pushed for hissing. Adora went to step in but Catra glared at her, warning her to stay back,

“I, Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon, commence the Royal Court session of Catra… Applesauce Meowmeow?” Glimmer tilted her head at the paper in front of her. Catra sent a glare to Adora; the one who chose her last name when they were being raised in the Horde, “You have committed treason more times than I can count, but your most recent crime was the kidnapping of Adora, the legendary She-Ra and commander of Brightmoon,”

At the mention of her name, Adora was beckoned to bow as a sign of respect to the queen. Adora stood upright, unwilling to bend over; her rebellion against the way Glimmer treated her. Glimmer rolled her eyes,

“How do you wish to rectify your actions, Catra,”

“I submit myself to a formal execution,” Catra stated blankly.

The silence in the room was painful as everyone awaited Glimmer’s response,

“Very well,” Glimmer. Adora’s veins pulsed with anger,

“You murderer!” Adora yelled, running towards Glimmer, “you made her do this!” Adora was jolted down by a taser, screaming out as she fell to the floor. Guards picked her up and escorted her. Catra’s eyes stayed clenched shut, unwilling to face Adora,

“You can't execute her, Glimmer. You're not thinking rationally,” Bow’s tone bared a warning, “She may be a bad person but you

can't justify killing someone,”

“I think it’s best if we have this conversation in private, Bow,” Glimmer gritted, narrowing her eyes at him,

“I quit my position as a front line force and tactician,” He stood tall, “I will not fight for Brightmoon when we're just as bad as the Horde,”

“She volunteered for this! I didn't do anything wrong!”

“We are supposed to be the good guys,” Bow finished weakly, leaving the room.

“Catra’s formal execution is scheduled in one week. Royal Court dismissed,”

The small crowd murmured with disapproval but Glimmer kept a neutral face- careful not to show any emotion.

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“Are you serious?!” Adora shouted as she barged into the holding cell Catra was in, “did Glimmer make you do this?!”

“You need to run,” Catra was desperate as she walked up to the magic barricade and held it,

“I promise you I'd stay and that's exactly what I’m doing!” Adora hissed,

“No. You aren't hearing me. You aren't safe here,”

“Neither are you! I’m going to find a way to get you out,”

“No,” Catra hissed, “my time is up,”

“What’s your problem?! They're going to kill you. Is it because you think I don't want you? Because I really want you-”

“Shut up!” Catra yelled, “maybe I want to be executed,” Catra lied,

“Don't say that,” Adora stressed,

“I was in the Horde. You really think I’m happy?” Catra resigned, “it's deserved, *Adora*,”

“Please, stop!” Adora screamed,

“No, because you just want to think of me as a morally grey person when I’m just a shit person. I killed the queen!”

“Don't lie! You said your kill count was zero. You pulled the lever but you didn’t kill her,”

“Yes I did. I pushed her into that oblivion and she’s been dead since,” Catra lied,

“I saw it happen!”

There was a chilling silence in the room until Adora spoke again. Her voice was chilling,

“You're trying to hurt me and make me run, but that will never work. Nothing you do scares me. You're just as human as me, and I’m *sick* of you pretending you aren't,” Adora felt her heart beat in her ear as silence ensued. Catra hissed and turned around. Adora let out an indignant scoff, leaving the room.

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“Not so strong now, are you?” Glimmer teased. Catra looked up at her with blurry eyes; she hadn’t moved in a day

“So what?” Catra growled, standing up, “you've taken everything from me. My headpiece, my privacy, my dignity, *my will to live*, the list doesn't end. When is it going to be enough for you?”

“I cancelled your execution despite all the atrocities *you've* committed. You're just trying to get in my head-” The smug and arrogant tone in Glimmer’s voice made Catra’s blood boil,

“No. The world just becomes crystal clear when there's nothing worth living for,” Catra finished, walking away, “you and the stupid rebellion don't care about anyone, you all just care about looking good,”

“We save villages and homes from the destruction that the Horde tries to cause!”

“You never cared about the orphans of the Horde,” Catra said in a low tone,

“You guys are bad people! How could we care,”

Catra snapped.

“We were children!” The tears started to head in Catra’s eyes but… no; she doesn't cry in front of people.

“Adora, Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle. I want you to remember those names when I’m dead. That was my squadron. There are 20 squadrons of kids every ten years, each one of them groups of five. One hundred innocent children and there was not one attempt from the rebellion to break into the Horde and save us,” Catra took a shaky breath in, trying to regather herself, “do you wonder why the Horde resents you so much, even that tiny part in Adora? This is why,”

Catra knows just when to pause, exactly when to take a break to watch Glimmer’s face process it,

“I have spent my whole life protecting that abused kid inside me from your sparkly corrupted rebellion, because you never made it safe for that kid I was,”

Glimmer’s gut twisted and she looked to the ground with burning shame.

“Kill me with your own hands or reschedule my execution for all I care, but don’t you ever call those orphans of the Horde ‘bad people’. They're the purest of kids subjected to far worse than you

can ever imagine and you're sick for thinking they're guilty of anything more than existing,”

Glimmer suffocated in the silence that followed, “I just want to avenge my mother,” She whispered,

“Leave!” Catra screamed, throwing the chair against the barrier. Glimmer teleported away instantly.

Being alone wasn’t bad, not when there was nothing left for Catra. No thoughts, no tears, no anger. Just emptiness,

-

“Eat it,” Glimmer said sheepishly, handing Catra a tray with food on it, “I used to eat these all the time as a kid. I figured you deserved to have the experience as well,” Catra didn't talk. She hadn't since three days ago, when she screamed at Glimmer. She hadn't eaten either, and she only drank water when she had to, “is there anything you want to eat?” Glimmer asked quietly, still very much overcome with shame. Glimmer was met with all consuming silence, so she stepped into the barrier, “come at me, Catra, hurt me with all you've got,” Catra didn't move, except to sluggishly turn away from Glimmer on the bed, “I’ve already cancelled your execution. I cancelled it as soon as Bow and Adora left. The rebellion is falling apart. Is this not what you wanted?”

“You don't get to *want* when you're raised in the Horde. You think as a group. It’s never about what I want it’s what the Horde wants,”

“You want Adora, don’t you?” Glimmer responded softly. Catra’s eyes widened,

“Don’t you dare.”

A threat settled behind Catra’s eyes. Glimmer swallowed saliva down her dry throat,

“Sorry. I guess I really want Bow. Thought it might be like that for you and Adora,”

“Go get him, you can have everything you want,” Catra spat. Glimmer sat against the barrier,

“He would never forgive me, I've turned into an awful person,” Glimmer muttered,

“Grief makes you do horrible things,” Catra mumbled, shuffling to sit next to Glimmer

“Never thought you’d sympathise with me. You have every reason to hate me,” Glimmer held her knees closer to her chest and Catra did the same,

“One day, in the far future. I’ll forgive you. Until then I just understand where you're coming from,”

“You don't have to,” Glimmer said,

“I know,” Catra shrugged, looking at her nails nonchalantly, “I hurt a lot of people grieving Adora,” Catra admitted quietly,

“Adora’s not dead,” Glimmer tilted her head,

“Felt like it when she left. She was my sense of safety. I stayed at the Horde because she was there. When she saw what the Horde was doing to the world she left. She never left when she saw what the Horde did to me,” Catra hugged her knees. Glimmer could tell that the topic was indefinitely nuanced,

“Oh,” Glimmer muttered, “that sucks,”

“Yep,” Catra hummed, “betrayal at its finest if you ask me,” The silence that followed was comfortable. Catra picked up the food Glimmer brought- a dumpling shaped thing- and took a bite, “This isn’t poisoned right?”

“No,” Glimmer laughed, ripping off a bit from Catra’s and eating it, “my mum used to make it for me when I was younger,”

“Nice,” Catra murmured, before staring at her knees, “do you have my headpiece?”

“The red thing? Yeah, just a minute,” Glimmer teleported and reappeared in seconds with it held in her hands, “why do you love it so much?” Glimmer asked, running her hand over the red metal before handing it back to Catra. Catra let out a shaky exhale, putting it on,

“I’ve never had much. But this, I’ve always had,” Catra picked at a scab on her knee, focusing on anything that wasn't Glimmer, “I guess, this was the only thing I’ve ever been gifted. You don’t get stuff in the Horde, really. Unless you’re Adora, she was just lucky that Shadow Weaver loved her so much,” Catra frowned at the memories; she couldn't help but feel a little spiteful, considering Adora got pencils and crayons and Catra got tied down and electrocuted,

“Oh,” Glimmer said blankly, “Shadow Weaver didn’t love her though,”

Catra croaked, “Bullshit. Try growing up through my eyes and tell me that after,”

“I’m serious, it’s an abuse tactic,”

“Get lost,” Catra hissed, stumbling away from Glimmer and facing towards the window,

“Catra?” Glimmer murmured,

“I would've done anything to be in her shoes. I wanted some higher-up to think I have potential, someone to believe in me. She had all of that and she left it,”

“I believe in you,” Glimmer said. There was a beat of silence

“You almost executed me. You thought I was better off dead,”

“No, I thought I could avenge my mum by killing you. I was wrong,” Glimmer insisted,

“You’re lying! You're trying to mess with me!” Catra seethed, pointing an accusatory finger at Glimmer, “you're just as fucked up as this whole system,”

“I promise I’m being honest,” Glimmer was surprisingly calm- she was never level headed to someone who was rude to her. But this was different. She was seeing the pieces of someone she broke apart, “I started a thing in your name called the Applesauce Project. We broke into the Horde last night, rescued 74 children. We’re heading back soon for the rest of them. We aren’t going to stop until we get them all,”

“Brightmoon can't handle that many kids,” Catra stated,

“Many of them were kidnapping victims. Very few kids are born into the Horde. So far 15 of them have been placed home, but we’re working on it,”

“Oh,” Catra muttered. She wasn't even sure how she was supposed to feel. She spent her life hating Brightmoon for pretending to be good but never protecting her from abuse and now they were saving the kids. All it took was telling someone who would listen, “do you think…” Catra’s voice trailed off,

“Go on,” Glimmer gestured for her to continue

“Do you think I have parents?” Catra asked softly. *Softly*; Catra felt herself writhe in her skin, before remembering nothing really mattered anymore. Who cares if she didn't have her defensive walls up, she was almost dead.

Glimmer stroked her chin for a moment, “I think it’s possible. I could try looking?”

“No, don’t waste your time,” Catra shrugged, walking over to the bed and surrendering to it,

“Adora is returning to her position in Brightmoon. She made it clear it was just for saving the Horde kids but I’m sure she’ll swing by. Finish this, okay?” Glimmer said, putting the meal she made on the bed next to Catra, “Goodnight,”

Glimmer teleported away, leaving Catra in the room alone.

Being alone wasn't awful, but the mention of Adora made Catra reel about her again. Maybe she still felt something, maybe she *did* want Adora,

“Catra?”

“Fuck!” Catra shrieked, frightened by Adora, “how long have you been there?”

“I can get you out,” Adora offered, ignoring Catra’s previous question,

“I don’t care anymore,” Catra stated blankly, rubbing the back of her neck,

“What's that supposed to mean?” Adora frowned,

“There's nothing left for me, Adora. So as far as I’m concerned I just don’t care,”

“Catra,” Adora whispered hoarsely, “I love you,”

Adora’s confession was messy, possibly at the worst time. Catra frowned as she looked back at Adora,

“You don’t have to love me back,” Adora whispered, pressing her head against the barrier, “but I’m here for you. You don’t have nothing, you have me,” Adora sighed, tears welling up in the corners of her eyes, “I just hope it’s enough… that I’m enough,”

“Leave,” Catra frowned, “I’m only going to hurt you,”

“You don't want me to leave,” Adora pointed out, “I promised you I'd stay. If you stand back from the barrier, I can disable it with this contraption Entrapta made, just give me a moment,”

Catra stepped up to the barrier, holding her hand against it. Adora narrowed her eyes at her, “I’m not letting myself hurt you. It’s not worth it Adora, for either of us. I’m over everything. I’m over with having to care because I’ve gotten used to being alone. It’s cold but it’s familiar,”

“You do care, Catra,” Adora whispered, “I know you care,” Adora rested her head against the barrier, “just trust me, please,” Adora stared deep into Catra’s eyes.

Catra stepped back.

Letting Adora shock the barrier and disable it.

As soon as it whirred down, Adora ran to hug Catra. Catra collapsed into Adora’s arms.

It was only a few weeks ago that Catra was strong, full of enough muscle to hold Adora captive. But now Catra was so weak her ribs were starting to peak through her chest.

“You need to eat, I can't believe Glimmer has starved you,”

“Glimmer didn't starve me,” Catra shrugged, “she convinced me to eat,” Adora made a grim frown of confusion,

“She almost executed you and now she's making missions in your name and helping you eat? She's so unpredictable,” Adora groaned,

She’s hurting too,” Catra responded, pressing her head to Adora's chest, “forgive her,”

“I’ll do that when she gets the guts to apologise,” Adora scoffed,

“Hey Adora? I’m still sorry,”

Adora paused, her hands in Catra’s hair stilling, “I forgave you long before you ever apologised,”

“We both know I don’t deserve that,”

“Yeah but I can’t help it,” Adora whispered. Catra hugged Adora tightly,

“I don’t know how to fix things,” Catra whispered, her eyes watering,

“I’m not sure either. Let’s just try,”

Chapter End Notes

thank you for reading! got this chapter out early cuz i wanted to be done with it!!

End Notes

let me know what you think!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!